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Research

This Month in Geopolitics: October 2026

Key events, themes and trends to watch in the month ahead

October 2026

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IMPORTANT RESEARCH DISCLOSURES LOCATED IN APPENDIX 1.

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At a Glance: Geopolitical events to watch in October 2026

Our monthly [Look-Ahead](#) covers a *non-exhaustive* list of key events, issues and themes to watch in the month ahead. The below map intends to serve as an executive summary, providing a list of the issues at a glance. These are covered in more detail in subsequent slides. For an overview of key events between October and December 2026, see our latest [90-day Geopolitical Risk Radar](#).



In the spotlight for October 2026: US-Iran war and EU-China relations



US-Iran war

Diplomacy appears firmly back in play. The past month saw continued fighting and renewed diplomacy. [Reporting](#) suggests that the US is prepared to extend troop deployments in the Middle East to 2027. Iran targeted both US forces in the region and some tankers moving through the Strait, but has been unable to prevent a significant [rebound in crude flows](#) through Hormuz. On 22 SEP, talks were mediated by Qatar, Pakistan and Egypt, and on 24 SEP, Iran presented the US with a seven-day roadmap to a ceasefire leading to a phased reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and a return to nuclear negotiations, conditional on a US lifting of its blockade of Iran, sanctions relief and broader cessation of hostilities. The Trump Administration rejected the proposal, but negotiations continue.

To watch will be whether October is the month the war transitions into a negotiated settlement, which may hinge on whether Iran is willing to make some concessions on sanctions relief and the nuclear question, and whether Trump is keen to demonstrate that the war has produced a political and economic result in the final weeks before the 3 NOV midterm elections. It is plausible that the current diplomatic channel could produce a temporary de-escalation mechanism as long as there is pathway around the broader nuclear issue.

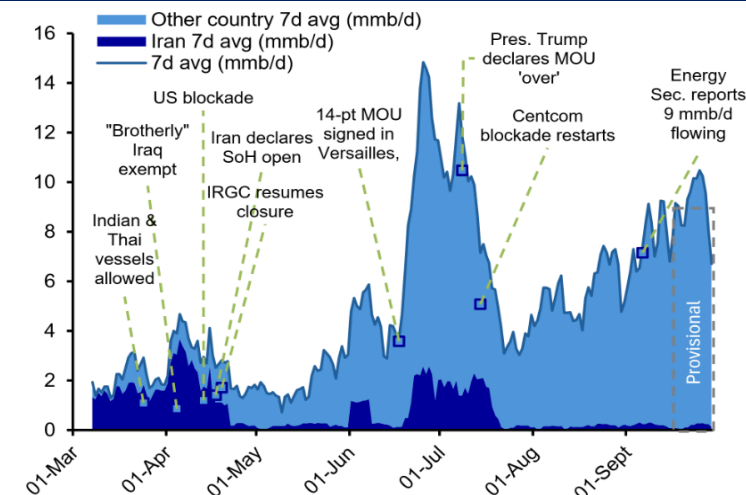
EU-China trade relations

Both sides will reconvene for trade talks in Beijing on 8-9 October, which the EU views as a deadline for “tangible results”. Brussels remains [focused](#) on its rising trade deficit with China – which has reached a record €1 billion per day – and the impact of Chinese goods on European industry. The bloc has vowed to take measures if talks fail.

While both sides could achieve progress in talks, a lasting breakthrough appears improbable, setting the stage for more trade tensions into 2027. New EU trade investigations, curbs on Chinese imports, and EU-level instruments intended to address alleged Chinese overcapacity, are possible outcomes, to which [Beijing has stated it would respond](#).

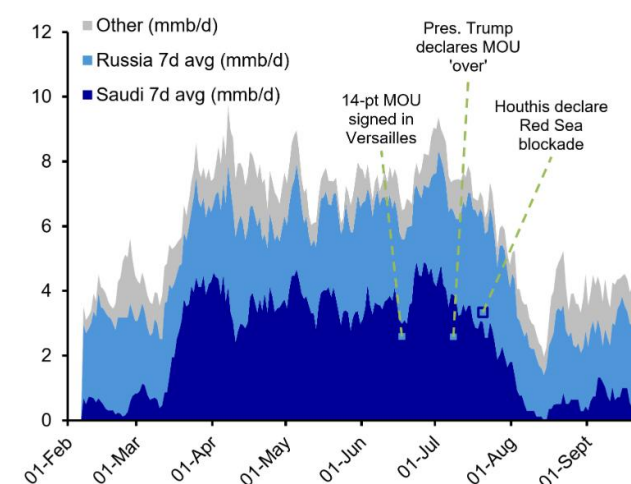
China-EU trade talks could also impact China-US relations. Should talks with Brussels fall short of averting increased European trade pressure, we assess that Beijing may further prioritise near-term US stability. See [Rules of Engagement: Mapping the Next Phase of China-US Ties](#) for more.

Strait of Hormuz total liquids exports (mmb/d)



Source: Kpler, Deutsche Bank Research.

Bab el Mandeb total liquids exports (mmb/d)



Source: Kpler, Deutsche Bank Research. For more, see: [Hsueh On Oil: Success of the shuttle system - Deutsche Bank Research](#)

Key events, issues and themes to watch in October 2026

Listed in chronological order



Latvian elections (3 October)

Latvia will elect all 100 members of the 15th Saeima. Latvia, which borders Russia and Belarus, has been among the most vocal supporters of Ukraine. The next government will set the country's course on defence spending, Ukraine aid, sanctions enforcement and border security. The field is highly fragmented with the governing parties lacking a majority in the polls. The fragmentation matters as a weakened and multi-party scramble could mean a slower, more unstable coalition.

General election in Brazil (4 October)

Brazil's first electoral round is on 4 OCT, with a runoff on 25 OCT. This is a critical election as it will decide whether Latin America's biggest economy continues President Lula's state-led social spending or pivots to a more fiscally-orthodox agenda under Bolsonaro. Polls have gone from a Lula lead in the spring to a statistical dead heat between Lula and Bolsonaro. A Brazilian Supreme Court crisis – which has implicated Supreme Court Justices and politicians on both sides – is weighing on the race. Congressional and gubernatorial races will also impact the governability of the country.

This election will also shape whether the country hedges between Washington and Beijing under Lula or tilts toward closer US trade and security alignment under Bolsonaro with potential implications for tariffs, BRICS+ cohesion, and Latin America's broader positioning between the two powers.

Annual meetings of the International Monetary Fund and World Bank (12-18 October)

The meetings will take place in Bangkok, bringing finance ministers, central bankers, policy-makers and business leaders together. The agenda is expected to centre on global growth, financial stability, debt, trade and investment, development finance and the impact of AI on jobs and productivity, with particular attention given to mobilizing private capital. The key watchpoint will be the outlook for global growth and inflation, debt vulnerabilities, the future of the international financial architecture and how policy-makers respond to increasing fragmentation in trade and capital flows.



Source: Waranont (Joe) on [Unsplash](#)

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European Council meeting (15-16 October)

Leaders are expected to focus heavily on Ukraine, European security and defence, competitiveness and the EU's economic position in a more contested global environment. They will also take forward negotiations on the 2028-2034 EU long-term budget. They set themselves a soft deadline in June to get the budget broadly locked down because missing it pushes ratification into 2027 and risks a funding gap for beneficiaries from JAN 2028. To watch will be a genuine breakthrough on the multiannual framework or more likely what “substantial” progress may look like. Ukraine funding is the other pressure point. This meeting will be important for understanding the direction of European defence spending and industrial policy, the next phase of budget negotiations and the EU response to growing external economic pressure and strategic dependencies.

Alberta independence referendum (19 October)

The Canadian province of Alberta will hold a referendum, which includes a question about the province's future within Canada. This is not an independence vote itself but asking voters to choose between remaining a Canadian province and asking the Alberta government to begin the constitutional process required for a future binding referendum on separation. Current polling suggests “remain” is comfortably ahead. The significance is around potential renewed uncertainty around Canada's federal cohesion, energy policy, fiscal transfers and Alberta's relationship with Ottawa and Washington. Even a modest agreement to begin a process towards secession would likely keep alive equalization grievances as a structural fault line in Canadian federalism feeding into political risk.

Berlin Global Dialogue (20-22 October)

The event's theme focuses on “Advancing Alliances in a New Era.” It will tackle how governments and businesses respond to a world where geopolitics, economic security, supply chains and technology are increasingly intertwined. There is likely to be a strong focus on the future of the transatlantic relationship, including how Europe adapts to a more demanding security environment. There will also be discussions of tariffs, supply chain resilience, critical capabilities and the weaponization of economic interdependence. It will align with Chancellor Merz's efforts to ensure Europe actively shapes outcomes around strategic autonomy and reducing China exposure in manufacturing.



Source: Bernd Dittrich on [Unsplash](#)

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Summit between the EU and the Gulf Cooperation Council (24 October)

The second summit will take place in Saudi Arabi, bringing EU and Gulf leaders together. The agenda is expected to focus on regional security and the Middle East, energy and economic security, trade and investment, infrastructure, technology and broader strategic cooperation. The security dimension will be particularly salient given the current crisis in the region. Economically, the relationship is substantial: EU-GCC trade reached €165.6bn in 2025.

To watch will be movement on the long-stalled EU-GCC free trade talks and visa-waiver requests from Qatar and Saudi Arabia in addition to the extent of the focus on Gaza reconstruction, Iran and regional security get relative to the economic agenda.

GCC states have consistently used these summits to press for clearer EU positioning on Middle East conflicts in exchange for economic cooperation. The summit comes amid at a critical juncture where Europe is recalibrating its external partnerships.

Fifth Plenum of China's Central Committee (26-29 October)

The Central Committee of the Communist Party of China will hold its Fifth Plenary Session in Beijing. This will be one of the most important events on the country's political calendar ahead of the 21st Party Congress in late 2027.

The Plenum will focus on Party governance, and investors will scrutinise signals regarding leadership changes and personnel reshuffles, institutional reforms, and political priorities for the next Congress. While fifth plenums historically focus on economic planning, the development guidelines for the 15th Five-Year Plan (2026–2030) were already adopted during the Fourth Plenum in OCT 2025, allowing the upcoming session to focus on personnel and governance matters.



Source: istockphoto

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Legislative election in Israel (27 October)

Elections will be held for the 26th Knesset, the first since the October 7th attacks and wars in Gaza, Lebanon and Iran. This is the first Knesset since 1988 to actually complete a full four-year term without early dissolution. Benjamin Netanyahu remains the dominant single figure but faces a fragmented field: Naftali Bennett's new "Together" party is polling as the main rival bloc, alongside Gadi Eisenkot's Yashar, Benny Gantz's Blue and White, and the further right Ben Gvir and Smotrich factions.

Israel's proportional system means the election is effectively about coalition formation. Key faultlines to watch: the ultra-Orthodox draft-exemption fight, how the war's legacy and hostage/reconstruction issues in Gaza factor into campaign messaging, and whether a Netanyahu-led bloc can reassemble a working majority or whether the Bennett/Eisenkot-style "anyone but Bibi" coalitions gain enough traction. The outcome will shape Israel's posture on critical regional issues, including Gaza reconstruction, Iran policy and West Bank settlement activity.

EU-Canada Summit (29-30 October)

This summit is shaping up as a particularly important juncture against a more ambitious push to redefine the relationship. During Mark Carney's SEP visit to Strasbourg, he called for a comprehensive strategic alliance with Europe. European Commission President von der Leyen went further, proposing that Canada become the EU's first "associate member".

The agenda is expected to centre on trade and economic security, defense, critical minerals, energy, digital cooperation and supply-chain resilience, building on the EU-Canada security and Defense Partnership in the EU's SAFE defense initiative. The summit will be watched for concrete progress on a digital trade agreement and broader economic cooperation.



Source: istockphoto

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G20 Foreign Ministers' Meeting (30-31 October)

The foreign ministers' meeting comes ahead of the December Leaders' Summit in Miami under the US' chairmanship of the G20 this year. Trump's G20 year has organized around four expert tracks – trade, innovation, energy and deregulation. The session is framed around economic prosperity, energy security and technological innovation, a much more transactional focus than previous foreign ministerials, which typically focused on geopolitical crisis management.

It will be a test of whether the G20 can sustain cooperation amid intensifying geopolitical fragmentation. In addition, Russia has confirmed its intent to actively participate in the meeting. This would further normalize Russia's multilateral engagement. For Europe and other partners, a key question will be the extent to which the G20 can be a forum for broader international cooperation.



Source: Lance Asper on [Unsplash](#)

Appendix 1



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